

Philipp Hilbert. *Senior Product Manager, complex regulated software.*

Positioning, ten years owning product in regulated, workflow-heavy B2B environments – now bringing that depth to Personio's Payroll domain.

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§ WHY PERSONIO

Payroll is one of the few product domains where correctness is not a differentiator but a non-negotiable – a wrong calculation does not just frustrate a user, it breaks trust with regulators and employees at once. Personio's explicit focus on making that domain user-friendly while staying compliant in a heavily regulated German environment is exactly the kind of dual constraint that makes product work interesting. The job description calls out cross-domain coordination, data-driven prioritisation, and close collaboration with Engineering, Design, and Compliance – the same operating model I have run at Rohde & Schwarz and Emil Group. *That combination of real stakes and real craft is what draws me here.*

§ HONEST FRAMING

I have not shipped payroll software directly. My regulated-domain experience comes from defence data platforms, public labour market analytics, and InsurTech – each with its own compliance ceiling. The transferable mechanic is strong: I have consistently decomposed legally constrained, multi-stakeholder workflows into clear engineering specifications and delivered them on time.

§ AI-NATIVE STACK

Daily tools, not buzzwords.

- **Claude**, spec drafting, edge-case generation, PR review

- **GPT**, research synthesis and competitive landscape summaries
 - **GitHub Copilot**, in-editor code assistance and test generation
 - **Cursor / VSCode**, codebase navigation and autonomous refactors
 - **Lovable**, rapid front-end prototyping before engineering commits
 - **Gamma.app**, stakeholder-ready slide decks from rough outlines
 - **n8n**, lightweight workflow and notification automation
 - **Framer**, interactive product mockups for design reviews
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§ TECHNICAL ENVIRONMENT

Shipped with, not just listed.

Python, Django, JavaScript, PostgreSQL, MongoDB, Kotlin (Spring Boot), Kubernetes, ArgoCD, Helm, Argo Workflows, OpenShift, Docker, Jenkins, Dagster, dbt, DuckDB, MicroStrategy, Redpanda, REST APIs, GitOps pipelines, Bitbucket, Git, AngularJS, Ionic.

§ SIDE PROJECT

BACKTEST ENGINE [GITHUB.COM/HILBERTP](https://github.com/hilbertp) →

Crypto market backtesting infrastructure built from scratch as a PM who codes.

- Ingests OHLCV data from multiple exchange APIs and normalises it into a DuckDB-backed local store.
 - Uses a file-queue-based agent loop to run strategy variants concurrently without a heavyweight orchestrator.
 - Covers execution realism: slippage models, funding rate simulation for perpetuals, and fee tiers.
 - Demonstrates the infrastructure-first product thinking I bring to data-heavy platforms like Personio's payroll calculation engine.
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§ HOW I WOULD WORK AT PERSONIO

First weeks, concrete.

WEEK 1

Listen, map, find the gaps.

Shadow payroll operations calls and support tickets, map the current calculation and authority-communication flows end to end, and identify where user pain and compliance risk intersect.

WEEK 2

Quantify and prioritise.

Pull usage data and error-rate metrics to size the gaps found in week 1, align with Engineering and Compliance on feasibility, and draft a first backlog cut with explicit trade-off rationale.

WEEK 3+

Ship, iterate, close loops.

Drive the first sprint cycle with clear acceptance criteria, run structured user feedback after each release, and begin building the cross-domain roadmap artefact the team can rally around.

I COVER LETTER

Dear Personio team,

Payroll is the product domain where a missed edge case is not a UX annoyance – it is a failed tax filing or a late salary transfer. I have spent the past several years working in environments with exactly that level of consequence: a defence AI platform subject to multinational audit requirements, a public labour market analytics system operating under IT-security officer oversight, and an InsurTech SaaS where regulatory correctness was the core value proposition. In each case the challenge was the same as the one Personio's Payroll team faces: translate a complex, legally constrained workflow into software that is both correct and genuinely usable.

At Emil Group I took over a payroll-scale complexity: a multi-module InsurTech platform serving primary insurers, reinsurers, and brokers, with a 17-person team that had lost sprint discipline under delivery pressure. I split the team into smaller, accountable Scrum units, reintroduced velocity tracking and structured refinement, and delivered a Claims Center module from concept to production. Client trust – which had eroded significantly – was rebuilt within weeks through weekly product workshops and transparent technical communication. At Rohde & Schwarz I owned a data management platform inside the FCAS defence programme, writing specifications that spanned data transformation, audit trails, and ExplainableAI compliance across multinational stakeholders, then delivering features end-to-end including implementation support and GitOps rollout.

The Personio job description asks for someone who can develop deep customer understanding, decompose complex problems in close collaboration with Engineering and Design, and lead

cross-domain topics. That is precisely the operating model I have built over nearly ten years. My approach starts with structured discovery – combining qualitative user sessions with quantitative usage and error data – and ends with a backlog that Engineering can actually execute against, with acceptance criteria that leave no compliance ambiguity on the table.

On the German language requirement: German is my native language, I studied and built companies in Berlin, and I have operated in German regulatory and government contexts throughout my career. I understand the specific register that German payroll and authority communication demands.

I would be glad to walk through specific product decisions or trade-off reasoning in a conversation. Thank you for your consideration.

Best regards, *Philipp Hilbert*

II CURRICULUM VITAE

§ BEARING

Senior Product Manager with nearly ten years of experience owning product in regulated, workflow-heavy B2B environments. Track record spans defence AI data platforms, public analytics infrastructure, InsurTech SaaS, and mobile healthcare – each requiring close collaboration with Engineering, Compliance, and cross-functional stakeholders under hard correctness constraints. Comfortable driving strategy, writing tight specifications, and running sprint cycles in parallel. AI-native practitioner who shortens the loop between discovery and delivery. Native German speaker with direct experience in German public-sector and compliance-adjacent product environments.

§ CORE STRENGTHS

- Regulated workflow decomposition into dev-ready specifications
- Cross-domain roadmap ownership and stakeholder alignment
- Data-driven prioritisation and OKR formulation
- Sprint discipline recovery and team restructuring
- End-to-end feature delivery including GitOps rollout
- Compliance-aware product design (IT-SV, SafeAI, audit trails)
- Qualitative discovery paired with quantitative usage analysis

- AI-native execution and rapid prototyping
- Founder-level ownership, low managerial overhead required

§ PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

ROHDE & SCHWARZ 2024, 2025

Product Manager, AI Data Transformation

- Owned product for a central AI and data management platform within the European defence programme FCAS, subject to multinational compliance and audit requirements
- Delivered data transformation, tagging, and reproducible pipeline features with full data provenance and audit trails (SafeAI, ExplainableAI)
- Delivered autonomous feature sets end-to-end: user stories, acceptance criteria, implementation support, testing, and GitOps-based rollout via ArgoCD
- Reduced deployment times from several days to 20–40 minutes by introducing GitOps
- Unblocked an infrastructure issue in OpenShift that engineers had deferred for over a year – resolved independently in one week
- Led cross-functional team of architect, data scientists, backend and frontend engineers, and QA

FEDERAL EMPLOYMENT AGENCY (BUNDESAGENTUR FÜR ARBEIT) 2023, 2024

Product Manager, Public Data Analytics

- Advanced the Arbeitsmarktmonitor analytics platform for regional labour market and demographic data, operating under strict data governance requirements
- Served as Deputy IT Security Officer (IT-SV) with accountability for compliance, governance, and data lineage
- Delivered labour shortage analytics, flexible regional comparison tooling, and modernised admin interfaces
- Introduced Dagster for automated ETL and indicator generation; standardised CI/CD with full test integration
- Migrated legacy systems to Kubernetes and managed major system upgrades without service interruption

EMIL GROUP 2022, 2022

Product Manager, InsurTech SaaS Platform

- Owned product for a B2B InsurTech platform serving primary insurers, reinsurers, MGAs, brokers, and underwriters – a compliance-heavy, multi-stakeholder environment directly analogous to payroll
- Designed and delivered a Claims Center module from concept to production rollout
- Re-established sprint discipline: split a bloated 17-person team into smaller Scrum units, reintroduced velocity tracking and structured refinement, and introduced ownership and deputy accountability
- Regained client trust in a prototype-stage environment through structured communication and weekly product workshops
- Reduced senior developer attrition from near-total to a single departure

CLINET PLATFORMS 2021, 2022

Product Owner, Mobile Healthcare App

- Delivered a mobile-first pilot app for hospitals across iOS and Android with strict deadline and scope constraints
- Owned core flows: digital anamnesis, meal and therapy plans, transport, chat, and patient document storage
- Integrated CGM interface into hospital information system workflows; managed legacy API and external database complexity transparently with stakeholders

§ FOUNDER & EARLY-STAGE EXPERIENCE

QCRYPT AG 2016, 2018

Product Owner

- Co-founded and owned product for a quantum-secure encryption solution based on one-time-pad keys and true-RNG hardware; designed for setup under two minutes without technical knowledge
- Served as deputy IT security officer; responsible for attack vector analysis and product security architecture

KVITT PAYMENT SOLUTIONS 2013, 2018

Founder & CFO

- Founded a group-based P2P payment product on a P2P backbone; owned PSP integration, full UX/UI design, and mobile app prototype
- Product was later acquired and operated by Sparkasse

AOK HEALTH INSURANCE – ITSCARE 2019, 2020

Proxy Product Owner

- Migrated internal webshop to Shopware including complex catalogue/API integration and configurable approval policies

§ LANGUAGES

German, native. English, C2.

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